



Contents lists available at ScienceDirect

## International Journal of Educational Research

journal homepage: [www.elsevier.com/locate/ijedures](http://www.elsevier.com/locate/ijedures)

# The assemblage of inanimate objects in educational research: mapping venture philanthropy, policy networks and evidence brokers<sup>☆</sup>

Emma Rowe

School of Education, Deakin University, Melbourne, Australia

## ARTICLE INFO

## Keywords:

Policy networks  
network ethnography  
venture philanthropy  
sociology of translation  
evidence broker  
inanimate object

## ABSTRACT

This paper draws on Ball et al.'s (2017) network ethnography, to investigate policy mobility and the assemblage of inanimate objects in educational research, in the form of an 'evidence broker'. It focuses on a national education research institute funded by the Australian Government, named the Australian Education Research Organisation (AERO). Positioned as essentially bipartisan and apolitical, AERO was incorporated in 2021 to accelerate the use of research evidence and set a 'national agenda'. As modelled on the UK's Education Endowment Foundation and the What Works Centre, it establishes important legislative precedents to collaborate with venture philanthropy. The policy network fundamentally reshapes the ecosystem including functionality of capital and power, translating things and ideas into policies that retain material affects.

## Introduction

The dingo fence, a network of wires and posts, runs from the southern coast to near the eastern coast in a squiggly line, almost twice the length of the United States-Mexico border. (Solomon, 2018, The New York Times)

A well-known icon of Australia, and one of the longest structures in the world that can be seen from outer space, is a dingo proof fence that runs a length of 5,600 kilometres (equivalent to 3479 miles)—a distance that is four times the length of mainland Britain—and cutting across three states in Australia. It controls the movement, diet and habitat of entire species, specifically kangaroos and dingoes, and it has resulted in a fundamental mutation of sand, wind-flow and vegetation growth (Fisher et al., 2021; Solomon, 2018).

The fence is a metaphor for how I'm conceptualising a policy network (Knox et al., 2006). It is an imposed, constructed object within a landscape, and it is purposefully assembled with the intention of driving large-scale systemic change within the landscape. The fence appears as an inanimate object yet radically alters living ecosystems into something *other*. It is an intrinsic part of the network that it constructs, although at first glance it appears to be simply a fence. It assembles and connects an entire network of things, objects and human actors—such as 'The Dog Fence Board', a governing body set up to administer and manage the fence, and senior executives who sit on the board; it assembles legislation, such as *The Dog Fence Act 1946*; patrollers who fight for 'competitive' contracts to patrol the fence; or even the cars, satellite phones, wire and poles, or poison baits that are used along the fence to maintain, uphold and strengthen it (Government of South Australia, 2021a, 2021b; Solomon, 2018). The fence retains its shape in Euclidean

<sup>☆</sup> Author notes: Emma Rowe ARC DECRA Fellow Deakin University, Burwood, Victoria  
E-mail address: [Emma.Rowe@deakin.edu.au](mailto:Emma.Rowe@deakin.edu.au).

space, and as a physical object it stretches across disparate vast landscapes, constructed as an inanimate object; but the fence holds its shape not only in Euclidean space—it holds its shape in relational, functional space connecting human actors, things and objects, such as legislation which is fragmented across three different states (Law & Singleton, 2005).

The policy network holds its shape but moves around, tying together both the physical and the abstract, acting as a ‘tool for thinking about long-distance control and, at the same time, the work that goes into moving scientific facts around, so producing their apparent universality’ (Law & Singleton, 2005, p. 335). These tools, instruments and objects are actively assembled within the social—‘you can’t make a social structure without this compilation work’ (Latour, 2002, p. 240)—and a policy network is assembled, not only of human actors; it is composed of talk and ideas that are embedded as government legislation, building a material and solid structure. Government legislation is shaped into policy that is assembled and ordered for schools and teachers. Law (1992) describes it as a continuum, writing that ‘thoughts are cheap but they don’t last long, and speech lasts very little longer’, but when we *perform* relations, and when we *embody* them in ‘inanimate materials such as texts and buildings’, they may last longer, and therefore,

...a good ordering strategy is to embody a set of relations in durable materials. Consequently, a relatively stable network is one embodied in and performed by a range of durable materials. (Law, 1992, pp. 387, emphasis in original)

The aim of this paper is to examine the policy network which successfully lobbied for a national evidence broker, the ‘Australian Education Research Organisation’ (hereby referred to as AERO), incorporated in 2021 and funded by the Australian Commonwealth and State Governments. It is yet to be researched in academic literature, and arguably it is an urgent area of critique which sits alongside research of similar institutes in the United Kingdom and United States (Anderson et al., 2017; Ball, 2007, 2012; Ball & Exley, 2010; Lubienski et al., 2011). It is useful to note Lewis and Hogan, 2019 research of the Centre for Educational Statistics and Evaluation (CESE), an earlier initiative of a research centre that was state-based (the director of CESE is now the public director of AERO).

AERO maintains three objectives according to its strategic plan<sup>1</sup>: First, AERO exists to *generate* ‘high-quality’ evidence; second, *distribute* ‘high-quality’ evidence that is relevant and accessible; and third, *accelerate* the use of evidence in the classroom, practice and policy (AERO, 2021d; Donovan, 2021). AERO consistently markets itself as unequivocally *bipartisan*, an independent ‘evidence broker’ (AERO, 2021b, 2021c, 2021d), assembling a range of instruments to construct its impartiality, such as randomized controlled trials (RCTs), or ‘evidence rubrics’ (research will be determined as ‘high-quality’ via an evidence rubric, as created by AERO) (AERO, 2021b). High-quality research will be determined through their ‘expert board’ (AERO, 2021a). AERO will allegedly remove ideology and factionalism, taking ‘politics out of the classroom’ (Karp, 2018). The evidence broker is represented and reliant upon epistemological constructs of ‘evidence’ as singular and impartial; and it seeks to translate this ‘impartial’ evidence via a range of durable materials, such as reports, evidence rubrics and RCTs.

The establishment of AERO occurred over a period of ten-years, as the product of sustained lobbying and funding from highly mobile and organised policy networks (see table 1). Whilst the organisation is represented as inanimate wires and poles held together—and notably, represented to the public in very considered, highly strategic ways—holding the fence together is a far more complex policy network, one that is embedded within venture philanthropy.

As I will set out in the paper, AERO is positioned within a network that transverses multinational corporations and governments, with both policy and funds borrowed and sourced from bankers, corporations and ‘big money’, located across geographically disparate spaces including the United States, Europe and the United Kingdom. Despite being geographically disconnected, the network is characterised by ‘overlap, multiplicity’ (Ball, 2009, p. 689), polycentric forms of relationality and ‘co-affiliation’ (Avelar & Ball, 2019)—with the networks typified by mutuality in donors, relations and policy borrowing. The following section maps the beginnings of AERO as a newly formed ‘evidence broker’.

### *Mobilising high-level reform: tracing the beginnings of AERO*

AERO endeavours to legitimise itself through a report colloquially known as ‘Gonski 2.0’. This report was initiated by the federal government in 2018, formally titled ‘*Through Growth to Achievement: Review to Achieve Educational Excellence in Australian Schools*’ (Australian Government, 2018). The report would colloquially become known as Gonski 2.0<sup>2</sup>, in reference to corporate consultant David Gonski, the first author. On all public surfaces and interconnections, AERO represents its logic of causation via the metaphorical and symbolic leverage of ‘Gonski 2.0’—this includes their website, detailing their origins (‘About AERO’, AERO, 2021a), reports on mainstream media (e.g. Urban, 2021); or, interviews with the CEO Dr Donovan on mainstream media:

The Australian Education Research Organisation...is an initiative that arises from Gonski’s review, in which it was identified as a good idea to have a really robust education base in education for both teachers and policy-makers to be making good evidence informed decisions about what they do in the classroom. (Donovan speaking to ABC News, 2021)

AERO seeks to legitimise itself via the cultural weight that ‘Gonski’ carries, as an epistemic label that is associated with the political left, and as Gonski is a widely known advocate for increased funding for public schools, it certainly makes sense to connect oneself to

<sup>1</sup> Although, note that the strategic plan presented on AERO’s website retains key differences to their Company Constitution (purchased from a corporate regulator), as will be expanded subsequently (ASIC, 2021b).

<sup>2</sup> The ‘Gonski 2.0’ (2018) report followed ‘Gonski 1.0’ (Australian Government, 2011). I have followed Gonski as a major nodal actor elsewhere (Rowe, 2021, Rowe, 2022a).

**Table 1**  
Timeline of key events

|             |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2002        | Social Ventures Australia (SVA) is launched, following national government legislation to foster corporate philanthropy ( <a href="#">Australian Government, 2002</a> ). SVA is a venture philanthropic organisation and initiative of McLean from McKinsey & Co ( <a href="#">Traill, 2016</a> ).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| 2011        | Driven by Hon. Michael Gove, UK's Education Secretary, the Education Endowment Foundation (EEF) was founded with funding from The Sutton Trust, Impetus, and a £125 million founding grant from the Department for Education ( <a href="#">Edoald &amp; Nevill, 2021</a> ). Gove was influenced by Michael Barber, the head of McKinsey and Co until 2011 (Gove, 2012).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| 2014        | The Education Endowment Foundation provide funding to the Australian-based 'Evidence for Learning' (E4L). E4L is a subsidiary of Social Ventures Australia, set up to address 'shortcomings' in education research ( <a href="#">SVA, 2016a</a> ). E4L stipulate their role is to lobby for a national independent 'evidence broker' in education and E4L is to serve as the pilot model ( <a href="#">Deeble &amp; Vaughan, 2018</a> ; <a href="#">SVA, 2018b</a> ). E4L is funded by SVA, the Commonwealth Bank of Australia, and the UK's EEF ( <a href="#">SVA, 2016a</a> ). E4L begin working with school systems in Australia to develop and trial an Australian version of EEF's 'Teaching and Learning Toolkit' ( <a href="#">EEF, 2021</a> ). |
| 2016        | The Australian federal government, via Treasurer Hon. Scott Morrison MP, commissions a formal inquiry into the 'National Education Evidence Base' via the Productivity Commission ( <a href="#">Morrison, 2016</a> ). Concurrently, a Director of SVA (Richard Spencer) is appointed Commissioner of Social Policy at the Productivity Commission ( <a href="#">ASIC, 2021d</a> ; <a href="#">Australian Government, 2016</a> ; <a href="#">SVA, 2016b</a> ). SVA tenders a 50-page submission to the Productivity Commission to advocate for the institute, using EEF as a model example ( <a href="#">SVA, 2016a</a> ).                                                                                                                              |
| 2016        | The final Productivity Commission report recommends an Australian evidence institute as modelled on the UK Education Endowment Foundation ( <a href="#">Australian Government Productivity Commission, 2016a, 2016c</a> ).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| 2017        | In July 2017, the Australian Government established the 'Review to Achieve Educational Excellence in Australian Schools'. It became known as Gonski 2.0 ( <a href="#">Australian Government, 2018</a> ).<br>The lead author is David Gonski, a former director of a subsidiary SVA company (Australian Philanthropic Services).<br>The final report released in 2018 makes a major recommendation for the education evidence institute (Recommendation 23, <a href="#">Australian Government, 2018</a> ). SVA continue to lobby for the institute ( <a href="#">SVA, 2018a, 2018b</a> ).                                                                                                                                                               |
| 2018        | The UK Education Endowment Foundation launch a five-year project titled "Building a Global Evidence Ecosystem for Teaching" in partnership with the BHP Foundation (from BHP Group, an Iron Ore Company) ( <a href="#">Collins, 2018</a> ; <a href="#">Edoald &amp; Nevill, 2021</a> ; <a href="#">EEF, 2018</a> ).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| 2018 - 2020 | The <i>National School Reform Agreement</i> stipulates that the Commonwealth and state government will provide \$50 million dollars in funding for AERO ( <a href="#">Australian Government, 2020a</a> ; <a href="#">COAG, 2018</a> ).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| 2020        | National legislation policy authorize AERO to collaborate with 'philanthropic organisations' ( <a href="#">Australian Government, 2020b</a> ).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| 2021        | The Australian Education Research Organisation (AERO) is incorporated and registered as a company limited by guarantee ( <a href="#">AERO, 2021a</a> ; <a href="#">Australian Government, 2020b</a> ).<br>The 'expert board' and directors of AERO includes a former SVA director; SVA donors; and former founding CEO of EEF (Sir Kevan Collins) ( <a href="#">AERO, 2021a</a> ).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |

the authority, status and leverage of 'Gonski' (see [Rowe, 2021](#)). This is strategically instrumentalised to acquire public approval and gain legitimacy in the education sector, especially since 'Gonski' was adopted as a verb in a campaign run by the public education union (#igiveagonski). (Although, this is quite a troubled association, as I will explain subsequently).

The evidence institute ties its legitimacy to a major recommendation of the Gonski 2.0 report:

Recommendation 23: [The Australian Government should]...establish an independent institution to coordinate the strategic development of a national research and evidence base through the sourcing and generating of research, and the synthesising and promotion of educational evidence that can be easily accessed and implemented to improve student outcomes. ([Australian Government, 2018](#), p. xiv)

This recommendation became a critical lever to impel the evidence institute forward, mobilising rapidly in fast policy in the form of legislation and money. Shortly thereafter the Gonski 2.0 recommendation, in the same year, the National School Reform Agreement committed to fund the institute ([COAG, 2018](#)). The Federal Government would provide \$25 million of funding and the states and territories would contribute \$25 million ([Australian Government, 2020a](#)). The so-called 'independent' government report (Gonski 2.0), authored by a corporate lawyer/consultant, long-time political lobbyist of philanthropy ([Gonski, 2015](#)), and the Director of Australian Philanthropic Services ([ASIC, 2021c](#)), provided the leverage required to gain public support and approval. 'Gonski 2.0' was represented to the public as an independent report, whilst obfuscating powerful scaffolds and agendas. Whilst AERO ties its legitimacy to Gonski 2.0, this omits a powerful network that led to the initiative of the evidence broker.

#### *Assembling the evidence broker*

Knowledge brokers or 'evidence brokers' are ubiquitous within corporate global education reform, as [Lubienski et al. \(2011\)](#) wrote ten years ago: 'new intermediary organizations are increasingly determining the body of research made available for the policymaking process by "brokering" evidence' (p. 1). The move to broker evidence in education is the purchase of authority and leverage in achieving large-scale and systemic policy change ([Ball & Junemann, 2012](#); [DeBray et al., 2019](#); [Scott & Jabbar, 2013, 2014](#)).

The term knowledge broker or 'evidence broker' draws from finance lineage; the broker acts as an intermediary between the buyer and the seller; brokers can be compensated in a range of ways, including commissions, fees or exchanges of value such as networking ([Investopedia, 2021](#)). These financier terms, such as evidence broker, or 'buy in', are scattered throughout the network to the extent they are unremarkable. But they point to important epistemic bindings that hold the network together. This was captured effectively by one prominent venture philanthropist who stated during their keynote, 'Money is the currency of our conversation' ([Conference, Philanthropy Australia, 2021](#)). This was agreed upon and echoed in almost every presentation subsequently as a shared 'way of seeing' ([Gorur, 2016](#)).

The network is held and bound together by perhaps the simplest of things but also one of the most complex of things—money. Yet money shouldn't be regarded here in entirely literal terms, and neither should be understood as inert or *known*; money is symbolic and figurative, but also entirely real and somatic; money is classificatory and classifying; money brings people together and fuses connections, it creates opportunities. The symbolic and tangible assembles the epistemological foundation that binds the network together in shared value systems. It reflects the ontological in *who they are*. The networks are dominated by financiers, particularly investment bankers and corporate consultants. It is dominated by consultants from McKinsey and Company, Bain and Co, or large conglomerate banks such as the Bank of America, and technology firms and related foundations, including Google, Facebook and the Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation.

Actor-network theory, writes Law, is concerned with relationality, materiality and performativity: the first approach 'tells us that entities achieve their form as a consequence of the relations in which they are located', but 'that it also tells us that they are *performed* in, by, and through those relations' (Law, 1999, p. 4, emphasis in original). The individual nodes have very little meaning or power by themselves; their power is acquired through their relationality, the institutions they perform with, the institutions they are linked to.

The transformation or translation occurs (the deformation), when these nodes interconnect with one another to form reach, power and leverage; for example, the Bank of America supports an educational foundation, which purportedly aims to improve educational equity, and in doing so, the bank endeavours to mutate its shape and transform its image from corporate money-maker to altruistic giver, in demonstrating 'corporate social responsibility' (Hogan et al., 2016). This transformation may exist in tension, and be problematic (Law, 1999), but the aim here is not to defuse the tension but rather recognise the complexity and intended translation.

To understand the remit and scope of AERO, it is important to study its interconnections—the relations in which they are located, and how these relations are performed. In doing so, and in examining how an 'evidence broker' in education is mobilized within a nation state, it is critical to think of power as strategically assembled, power as put together, rather than power as predetermined or existing out there as a distinct set of hierarchical structures (e.g., the traditional government). This positions power 'as a (concealed or misrepresented) effect, rather than power as a set of causes' (Law, 1992, p. 387). AERO relies upon public representations that are assembled in purposeful ways. These will subsequently be explored as scaffolding, following a discussion of how theory informs method.

#### *Methodology: theory and method*

This paper is based on a broader three-year long study into venture philanthropy in public education, beginning in mid-2021 (Rowe, 2021, Rowe, 2022b). The study draws upon network ethnography, aligned with work by Ball and colleagues (Ball, 2016; Ball & Junemann, 2012; Ball et al., 2017), utilising comprehensive web-based searches, reports, databases and interviews, in order to follow people, things, ideas, money and policy. The broader study includes interviews with major nodes from Social Ventures Australia, Schools Plus and Philanthropy Australia (see Rowe, 2021, Rowe, 2022b). However, interviews are not drawn upon in this particular paper for reasons of relevancy.

Thinking with Ball (2016), the paper questions how policy networks remake important ecosystems in education, and retain material affects into policy, schools, teaching practice and redefine 'high-quality' research, essentially redefining what matters in educational research. These networks are assembled as inanimate objects and yet they hold together a complex web of material affects.

I focused on AERO as the starting point of analysis (Scott & Jabbar, 2014), but as this was followed through I realised that AERO was neither starting point nor end point; the organisation is the visible representation of a travelling policy, and whilst this paper utilises a venture philanthropic organisation (Social Ventures Australia) as a critical centre-hub, the policy as peripatetic circulates within a network denoted by 'a high degree of epistemic homophily' (Ball, 2016, p. 5). The method pays attention to how the policies are held together by things, objects and human actors, and how the policies come to be structurally *embedded* (Ball et al., 2017).

For this study, the data was sourced from:

- 1 Australian Securities and Investments Commission (ASIC). ASIC is a national corporate regulator, and each company must submit the names of Directors, Company Constitutions and so forth, to ASIC. This is a more formal (and less public) account of their company. I compared formal company records for multiple organisations, including AERO, Social Ventures Australia (SVA), and each of their subsidiaries including Australian Philanthropic Services (APS). A total of 17 reports were purchased from ASIC (see, complete list appendix 1).
- 2 The Australian Charities and Not-for-profits Commission (ACNC): Financial profiles, reports and directors are freely available (2013- current).
- 3 Australian Government reports, legislation, correspondence with Departments, reports and publications; Productivity Commission Reports (Australian Government Productivity Commission, 2016b, 2016c).
- 4 Websites, reports, and publications of hubs and nodes: UK Education Endowment Foundation (EEF), The Sutton Trust, Impetus; AERO; Social Ventures Australia (SVA) and their subsidiaries- Evidence for Learning and Australian Philanthropic Services (APS); Philanthropy Australia.

The paper draws upon Commonwealth legislation, in addition to correspondence with ASIC (2021), the Australian Taxation Office (2021) and the Commonwealth Department of Finance (2021). AERO Financial Reports were requested via the *Freedom of Information Act 1982* (November 2021), but AERO financial records are not currently obtainable (see appendix).

This method is exploratory, investigating, and scrutinising and seeks to reflect a critical lens; that is, it is epistemologically concerned with power and the struggle of power; power as concealed and misrepresented to the public (Law, 1992). The methods reflect

the epistemological framework that drives the paper forward, that is, the public representation of nodes differs to the private ‘bits and pieces out of which they are composed’ (Law 1992, p. 386). Studying policy networks means a continual reaching across and between (Ball, 2016), recognising that the representation of nodes is frequently very different to the infrastructures that underpins and leverages their authority and capacity to mobilise policy.

#### *Assembling inanimate objects: Translation as contingent and strategic*

AERO is registered as an Australian public company limited by guarantee, under the *Corporations Act 2001*<sup>3</sup> (ASIC, 2021a, 2021b; Australian Government, 2001). However, their public website does not use this language, rather stating they are a ‘ministerial-owned company governed by a Board’ (AERO, 2021a). AERO’s dual functionality of part-government and part-company encapsulates network governance, as heterarchical coordination between bureaucracy and market, governing via selective networks, as opposed to ‘governance without government’ (Rhodes, 1996). Governance via selective networks is coordinated by the state: under a number of legislations, the national government is authorised to participate in the forming of AERO as a company<sup>4</sup> (Australian Government, 2013, 2020b):

“The Commonwealth may form or participate in forming, a relevant company (see section 85)” (Author Correspondence with Public Governance, Performance and Accountability, Department of Finance, Canberra, November 2021).

This would appear as relatively benign rules but following this through illuminates how the state establishes governance networks. AERO is enabled via the *Corporations Act 2001*, introduced under a suite of reforms to foster ‘corporate philanthropy’ (Australian Government, 2002)—as facilitated by the government advisor, David Gonski, appointed by then Prime Minister John Howard (Gonski, 2015). Evidently, within this network, there are consistent relational patterns, which become structurally and materially embedded. Concurrently, the venture philanthropic organisation, Social Ventures Australia, committed to ‘revolutionising’ venture philanthropy in Australia, emerged in 2002 (Traill, 2016)—as a company limited by guarantee under the same *Corporations Act 2001*. The repetitive material enactments and embodiments, from relational into legislation, highlight opaque relations between market and government.

Furthermore, by following the policy, it can be found that national government legislation mobilized for AERO, under the Morrison Government (dated 21 September 2020), which states that AERO exists,

To strengthen the national education evidence base for schools ... through:

- a) collaborating with government, the school and early childhood education
- b) sectors... higher-education and research sectors, and *philanthropic organisations*;
- c) developing and implementing a national agenda for research...(Australian Government, 2020b, pp. item 8, section 5, my emphasis)

This objective is reiterated on two separate occasions in AERO’s Company Constitution, purchased from ASIC (2021b, pp. 6, 8). Directors should be appointed on the basis they have appropriate skill and experience in ‘engagement with the philanthropic community’ (ASIC 2021b, pp. 8). However, AERO’s stated objective, *to build the national education evidence base by ‘collaborating with philanthropic organisations’*, or appointing Directors on their qualifications in this area, is not specified on their website, or their associated reports or publications at time of writing (AERO, 2021a, 2021b, 2021c, 2021d). Neither was this legislative change reported in the mainstream media.

The formal legislative authority to collaborate with philanthropic organisations is significant when considering how this is assembled into a stable network, as reliant upon a set of ideas (Law, 1992). This reform anchors philanthropic organisational involvement into the national fabric of educational research.

As I will set out, AERO is a public expression of a far-reaching and complex policy network, and whilst it is polycentric and expansive, with webs connecting to policy borrowing from global conglomerates, a useful hub to situate this within is Social Ventures Australia (SVA), a venture philanthropic node. Metaphorically speaking, AERO is simply the *visible expression*—the ‘tip of the iceberg... all the (indispensable) invisible work lies below the waterline’ (Law & Singleton, 2005, p. 337). The subsequent analysis draws upon the notion of scaffolding, to indicate how AERO represents the visible component of the policy network scaffolding, obfuscating how and what props it up, giving it power and authority.

#### *Scaffolding One: Tracing venture philanthropy*

To understand the mobilisation of AERO, it is necessary to utilise a much wider lens. The following timeline endeavours to briefly summarise the major policy mobilities that led to AERO (see Table 1):

Social Ventures Australia (SVA) is the largest venture philanthropic organisation in the Australian social impact investment market, with a series of numbers to attest to their size and impact: a current fund of \$150 million under management (SVA, 2021, p. 8); or an annual income of 1.2 million from government grants; or 6 million from donations; a profitable consultancy arm that leverages almost

<sup>3</sup> Note that AERO is registered as Australian Education Research Organisation Limited (see ASIC records, 2021a, b, c, d).

<sup>4</sup> See: item 8 of section 5, the ‘Public Governance, Performance and Accountability (Relevant Company) Rule 2016’ (Australian Government, 2020b) for the purposes section 85 of the ‘Public Governance, Performance and Accountability Act 2013’ (Australian Government, 2013).

ten million per year. Financial records indicate that SVA receives sizeable grants from the government which exceed the amount of money they give away via competitive grants or donations (ACNC, 2021). SVA is registered as a not-for-profit—but are also profitable, and they are exempt from paying income-tax, amongst other concessions (SVA, 2013, 2014, 2015, 2018, 2019, 2020). All donations to SVA are tax deductible, functioning as a tax shelter for big business (Australian Business Register, 2022).

SVA was founded by big business in 2002, the brainchild of Robert McLean from McKinsey and Company (McLean is now the Director of Centre for Independent Studies; and Board member for The Paul Ramsay Foundation<sup>5</sup>); and received corporate support from AMP Bank (AMP Foundation), amongst others (Traill, 2016). To state that the SVA node is complex, entangled and far-reaching is an understatement; they are the ‘peak’ venture philanthropic organisation in Australia, and this is achieved through their sizeable and formidable connections to corporations but also foundations (e.g., they receive pro-bono consultancy from McKinsey and Co, and the Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation). The aim was to ‘revolutionize’ venture philanthropy in Australia, as writes the first CEO in his autobiography:

A lot of the work and thinking behind Social Ventures Australia drew on overseas examples, particularly in the US, of emerging venture philanthropy organisations. ‘Venture philanthropy’ describes the idea of bringing venture capital and private equity disciplines, funding and support to selected social entrepreneurs. The global contacts [made through Rob McLean- old McKinsey colleagues] were to be an ongoing feature of SVA, allowing us to learn from the best. (Traill, 2016, pp. 71, 74)

Their connections to McKinsey and Co tend to be omitted from public documents or submissions (SVA, 2016), although their origins are described in more detail in a former Director’s autobiography (Traill, 2016). The following figure endeavours to show their expansive network, but again this is only partial (see figure 1):

To understand AERO as an assemblage of a stable set of relations, it is necessary to follow policy and consider relations outside of the nation-state (Gulson et al., 2017). AERO publicly ties its logic of causation to singular and ‘independent’ consultancy reports, but it models itself on similar *objects of knowledge* including the UK Education Endowment Foundation (EEF) and the US Institute of Education Sciences, developed during the Bush Administration (Australian Government Productivity Commission, 2016a, 2016c). This is important for how these networks globally translate and disseminate, assembling their ideas, talk and concepts into durable and ‘impartial’ constructs.

#### *Scaffolding Two: Shadow nodes and corporatized policy networks*

The establishment of the Education Endowment Foundation (EEF) is informative for how it illuminates the role of the government in establishing corporatized policy networks. In providing a 125 million pound founding grant for EEF (Edovald & Nevill, 2021), the UK Department for Education wrote that the foundation ‘is being established from the money that was set aside when the Government took the decision not to increase the number of free school meals initiative’ (Department for Education UK & Gove, 2010). Whilst the explanation is verbose, in simplistic terms, the funding for EEF is derived from the free school meals initiative. Throughout the policy network and the mobilisation of fast policy, it is evident that the government is far more than a ‘shadow’ node but plays an active role in the formation and strategic assemblage of a corporatized policy network.

At each frame, the *public* representation of the node does not speak to the power that it is nested within, and interacts with (Latour, 2002). The EEF is committed to ‘improving equity’ for young people (even whilst it takes money for free school meals); and is funded by The Sutton Trust and the private equity firm Impetus: nodes that are funded by an assortment of multinational corporations—the largest global banks, investment companies, law firms and consultancies—highlighting how it is not only fast policy that is borderless and travels between transnational geographies (Peck & Theodore, 2015); but it is *money* that binds connections and characterises the convergence between particular nodes; with money flowing from the Bank of America, Goldman Sachs or JP Morgan to an education foundation in the UK. This education foundation in the UK would consequently interact with a multinational iron ore company to fund a venture philanthropic network in Australia.

The following figures show a brief snapshot of the funders of The Sutton Trust and Impetus (see figure 2 and 3):

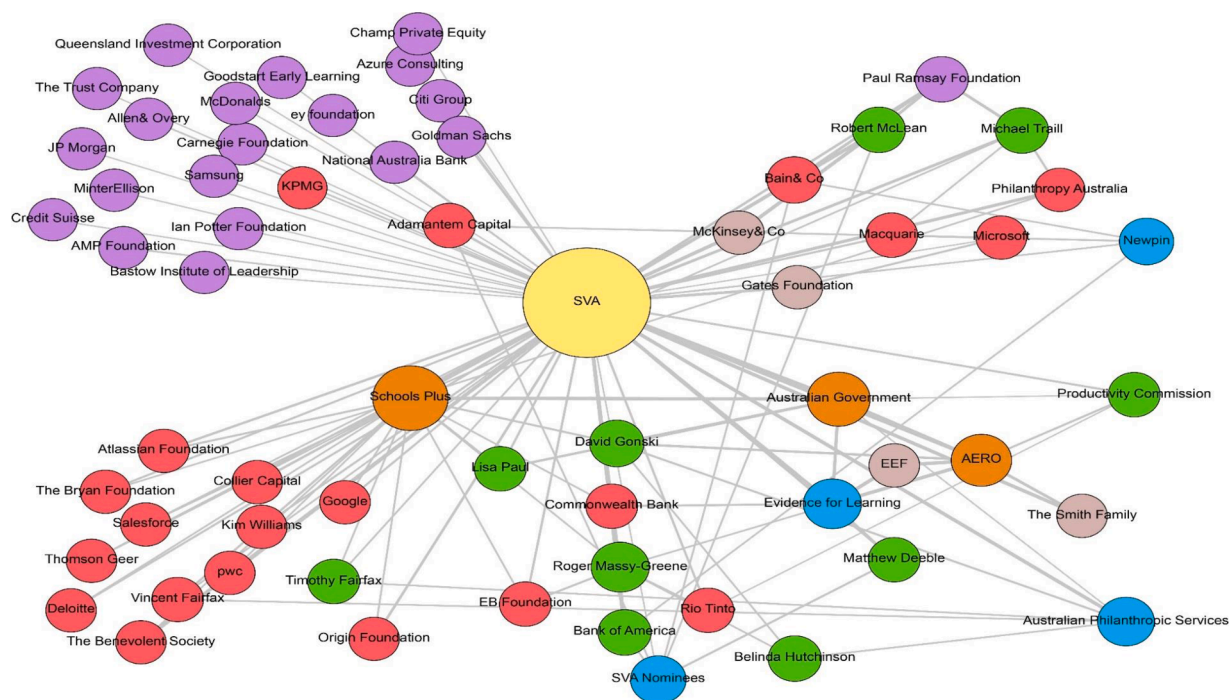
In 2014, when the network sought to expand its reach globally, EEF provided funding to ‘Evidence for Learning’ (E4L). E4L was to serve as a pilot model for a nation-wide evidence institution (an Australian version of EEF). As directed by a former corporate lawyer, Matthew Deeble, without any experience as a classroom teacher or school leader, Evidence for Learning began replicating, reproducing and trialling EEF’s ‘evidence and learning toolkits’, as funded by EEF and The Commonwealth Bank of Australia. They first trialled these toolkits in partnership with the Victorian Department of Education in 2015 (EEF, 2021).

Evidence for Learning continually reproduced the claims of independence, which would subsequently be replicated by AERO, writing:

Crucially, we are *independent* of all providers and funders of schooling, program and service providers, researchers and agencies. This enables us to commission, develop and present and promote evidence to school leaders and teachers to assist them make (sic) better investment decisions. (Deeble & Vaughan, 2018, p. 11, author’s emphasis)

Their claims of independence of all providers and funders are questionable; they are, of course, funded by SVA and EEF—two organisations which are then funded by numerous multinational corporations. Yet the crucial point here is that Evidence for Learning

<sup>5</sup> The Paul Ramsay Foundation is one of the largest philanthropic charities in Australia. It is the highest funder of ‘Teach for Australia’.



**Figure 1.** This endeavours to show SVA's expansive and complex policy network, although this is only a partial glimpse. The purple nodes represent donors, whereas the red are 'double-up' donors (donate to one of their subsidiaries or intermediaries). Their donors represent some of the largest global corporations. The blue nodes are subsidiaries. The map emphasizes multiplicity, overlaps and heterarchical structures. Abbreviations: SVA stands for Social Ventures Australia; pwc stands for PricewaterhouseCoopers; EEF is the UK Education Endowment Foundation; AERO is Australian Education Research Organisation.

is merely a proxy and representational surface, and underneath this surface is an entanglement of human actors attached to institutional power, flows of money and legitimised via government authority. Evidence for Learning merely serves as a subsidiary for venture philanthropic organisation Social Ventures Australia (SVA). (*To add to the complexity, the Gonski-directed 'Australian Philanthropic Services' is a subsidiary of SVA*<sup>6</sup>) (ASIC, 2021c, 2021d).

SVA created Evidence for Learning in 2014, as modelled on EEF, in order to 'address shortcomings identified in the education evidence ecosystem in Australia' (SVA, 2016, p. 11, author's emphasis). In one of their numerous submissions to government, SVA write, 'having looked at international systems, SVA created Evidence for Learning to pilot an Evidence Broker in Australia. Having proved the model, a solution is now needed at scale' (SVA, 2017a, p. 1). Evidence for Learning is the emblematic expression of what this venture philanthropic organisation regards as deficiencies in education research, a common sentiment expressed within these networks (Ball & Exley, 2010).

Their lobbying resulted in influence within high-level government and subsequently in 2016, the Australian federal government, via Scott Morrison, commissioned a formal inquiry into the 'National Education Evidence Base' to be carried out by the Productivity Commission (Morrison, 2016). The same Minister concurrently appointed one of SVA's Directors as a Commissioner at the Productivity Commission (Richard Spencer)<sup>7</sup> (Australian Government, 2016).

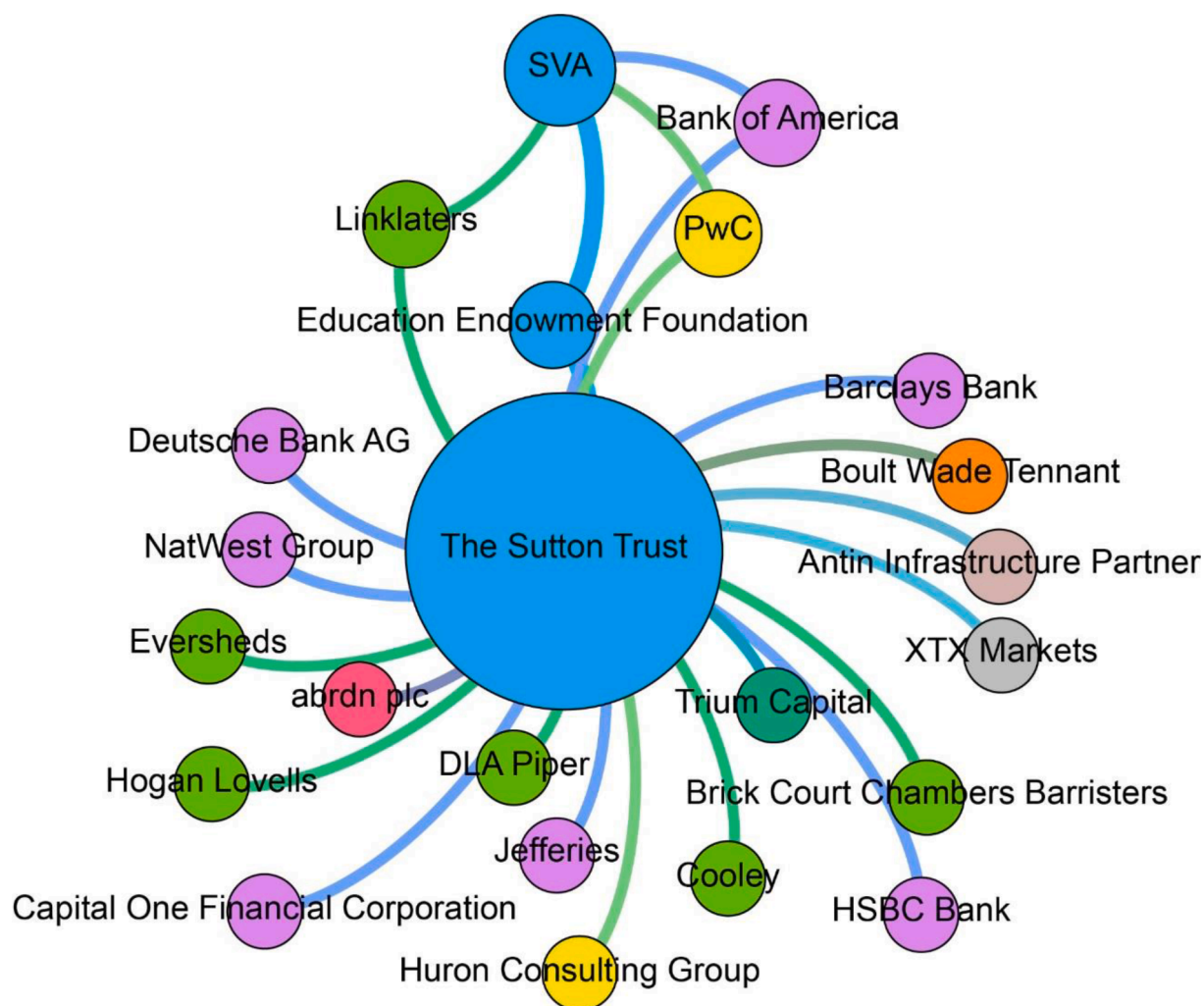
The Commission wrote in their report:

The Commission is proposing [a research institution] drawing on those observed internationally, including the UK Education Endowment Foundation and the US Institute of Education Sciences. (Australian Government Productivity Commission, 2016a, p. 20)

The recommendation reflects the 50-page submission SVA tendered to the Productivity Commission (SVA, 2016), in which they write, 'we hope to be a valuable contributor to the efforts of the Commission to improve the data and evidence landscape in Australian education' (p. 4). Shortly thereafter, in July 2017, the Gonski 2.0 report was initiated, led by a director of a subsidiary SVA company

<sup>6</sup> According to current ASIC (2021c, 2021d) records, Australian Philanthropic Services is a subsidiary of Social Ventures Australia. However, financial records obtained from the ACNC database note this relationship ended in 2017 (see, SVA, 2017b).

<sup>7</sup> SVA Directors are frequently appointed to high-level government roles. Morrison would later appoint former SVA Director Michael Trill to a senior government taskforce (Australian Government, 2021).



**Figure 2.** The Sutton Trust funds the Education Endowment Foundation (EEF), who then fund SVA. EEF is the public representation –funded by a diverse range of multinational corporations. This figure shows only a small proportion of the funders. It is characterised by multinational investment banks, law firms and consultancies, or algorithm trading companies. There are co-affiliations and overlaps with funders (e.g. Bank of America, PwC) who also fund SVA.

(Australian Philanthropic Services). In the same year, the UK EEF launched a five-year project titled “Building a Global Evidence Ecosystem for Teaching” in partnership with BHP Group, an Iron Ore Company (the BHP Foundation) (Collins, 2018; Edovald & Nevill, 2021; EEF, 2018).

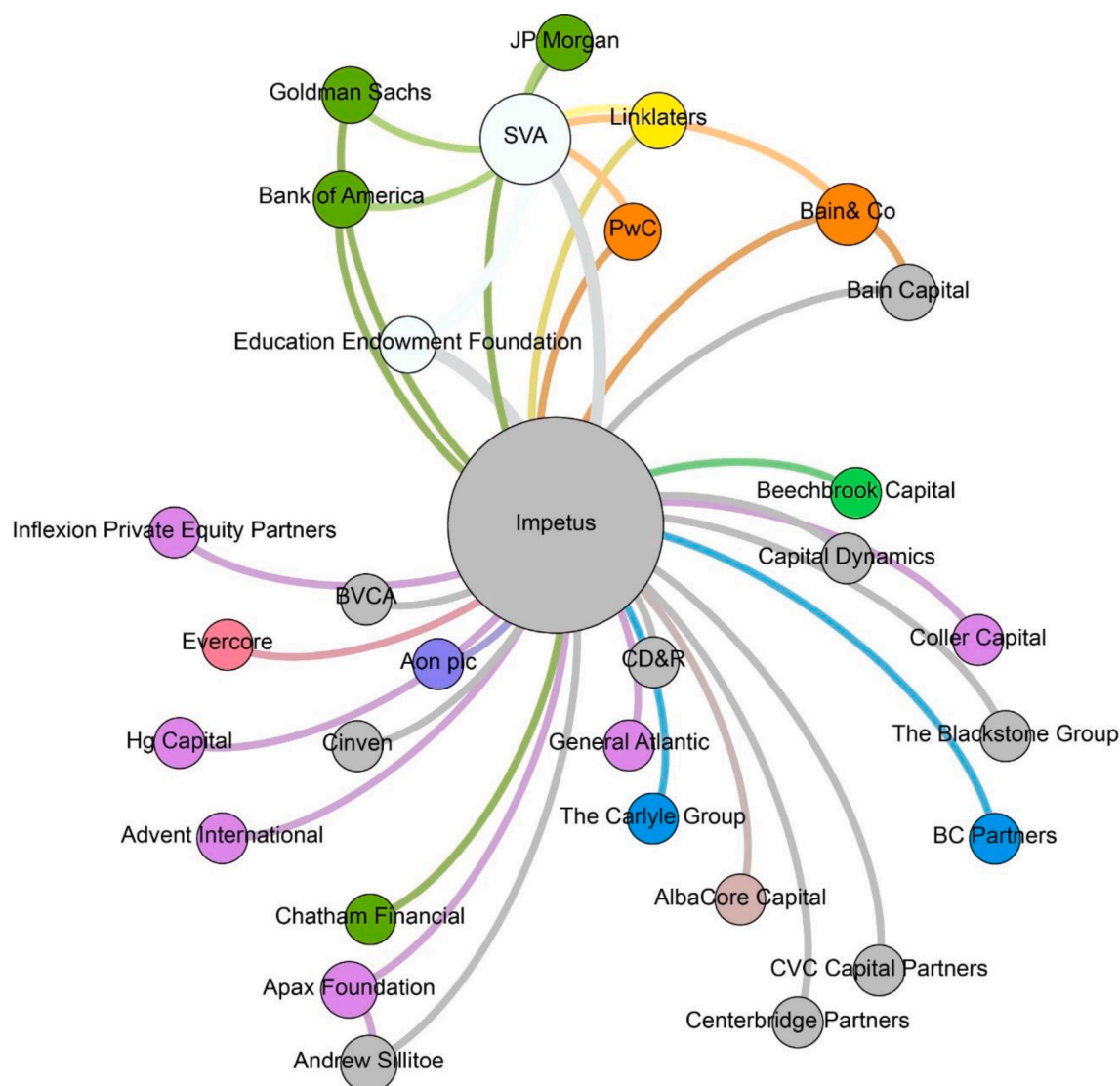
By 2019, the Australian National School Reform Agreement was signed (COAG, 2018; Education Council, 2019) and committed to \$50 million dollars in funding for AERO (Australian Government, 2020a). The Australian Education Research Organisation (AERO) was incorporated in 2021 to establish a ‘national research agenda’ (AERO, 2021a; Australian Government, 2020b). Even though AERO attributes its logic of causation to Gonski 2.0, SVA were lobbying for the organisation at least since 2014 when they set up Evidence for Learning.

#### *Scaffolding Three: Identifying co-affiliations, multiplicity, overlaps*

Ball and Exley’s (2010) writing about policy networks show how members move between sites sequentially and concurrently, a common feature of the network that AERO is positioned within. Policy networks are,

... social structures *and* relational processes... Network members move between sites and across the private and public sectors. They move within and across nations. Many have multiple positions, sequentially and concurrently. (Ball & Exley, 2010, p. 155, emphasis in original)

The network is characterised by ‘co-affiliations’ (Avelar & Ball, 2019), providing numerous ‘opportunities for things like ideas to flow between actors’ (Borgatti & Halgin, 2011). The following figure shows overlaps and commonality, by focusing exclusively on the

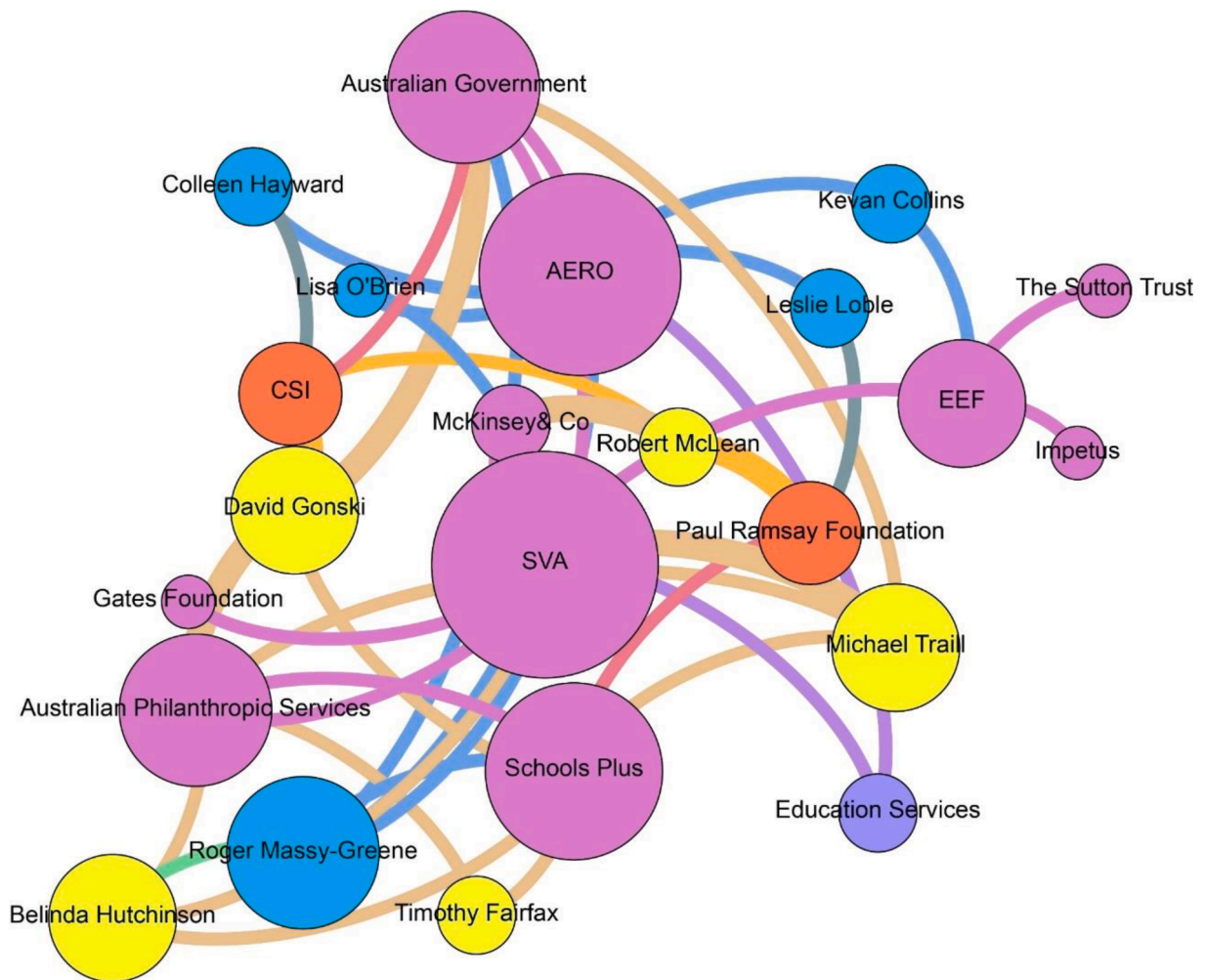


**Figure 3.** Impetus funds the Education Endowment Foundation (EEF). Impetus is funded by a wide number of multinational corporations yet retains similarities with The Sutton Trust in type and scope of funders—characterized by private multinational equity firms, consultancies, investment banks, and financial services. There are particular nodes such as Bank of America, Linklaters, PwC which are duplicated between multiple nodes (Sutton Trust, SVA, Impetus).

‘expert board’ of AERO (2022), who are also the formally registered Directors (ASIC, 2021a), and mapping the individual nodes to their links, ties and ‘co-affiliations’ (see figure 4):

There are numerous co-affiliations between AERO and SVA; for instance, the registered address of AERO is a donor to SVA (ASIC, 2021a). The Chair of AERO’s ‘expert board’ is former SVA Director (2011–2013), Lisa O’Brien; the board of directors includes Sir Kevan Collins, from the UK Education Endowment Foundation (EEF) (ASIC, 2021a). Roger Massy-Greene, director and expert board member, is a former Rio Tinto and Bank of America executive. Massy-Greene is a long-term donor to SVA and part of the ‘Pioneers in Philanthropy’ network (Schools Plus, 2019, set up by SVA (Rowe, 2022b); he is married to Belinda Hutchinson (a Director of Australian Philanthropic Services, alongside David Gonski, Michael Traill and Timothy Fairfax). Leslie Loble is a Fellow from the Paul Ramsay Foundation, a foundation which is chaired by Michael Traill from SVA, and includes Robert McLean on the board. The relational patterns are constant, indicating repetitive interconnected relational patterns between predominant nodes and hubs, then materially embedded within policies, legislation and reforms.

Certainly, it is a network that stretches across and between, characterised by consistent multiplicities and co-affiliations. AERO is the visible representation—the tip of the iceberg (Law & Singleton, 2005)—and it is expressed and sold as a fundamentally *neutral* and bipartisan establishment. The networks base their authority on claims of independence, impartiality and brokerage, endeavouring to render *evidence* as neutral and singular (Holloway & Larsen Hedegaard, 2021). AERO is performed as ‘inanimate materials’, one that



**Figure 4.** The blue nodes are Directors for AERO according to ASIC (2021) records. I mapped the blue nodes to their shared mutuality in the network, and their relational affiliations. For instance, Roger Massy-Greene is a director/expert board member of AERO plus a former Bank of America and Rio Tinto executive. He connects to multiple affiliations and he has been a consistent funder of SVA since 2015 (via his Foundation). CSI is the Centre for Social Impact, set up by Gonski.

will supposedly reproduce more ‘inanimate materials’ to circulate in the classroom (Law & Singleton, 2005). However, as a selective network that is problematically ‘public’, it is highly questionable whose interests they are serving.

### Concluding discussion

This paper has mapped the assemblage of a nation-wide ‘evidence broker’, the Australian Education Research Organisation (AERO). When AERO was finally established in 2021, it was publicly tied to independent inquiries, notably the Gonski 2.0 (2018) Report. This representation sought to give AERO a more credible democratic foundation, and at no point, it is publicly linked to a venture philanthropic organisation (SVA) that was initiated by senior management from McKinsey and Company. Nor is it represented as a company registered under the Corporations Act, that has legislated a foundational and critical policy mobility—the legislative capacity to ‘collaborate with philanthropic organisations’ in order to build an evidence base and set a ‘national agenda’ in educational research (Australian Government, 2020b). It is suggested that the inquiries and reports were instrumentalised for the purpose of scaffolding public leverage, and the appearance of democratic process. The government is far from a shadow node, and rather advances corporatized education reform.

The concern of organisations such as this are the precedent they set for the redistribution of funding to public schools and fragmentation of the role of the state, formally authorizing collaboration with profit-driven philanthropists. This ‘public’ research organisation, which is funded by the public purse, is entitled to outsource its services for profit and outsource services to consultants—whilst redistributing money away from public education. Arguably, AERO exists as a means to purchase ‘evidence’ and legitimise reforms; to usher in reforms quickly through its forms of legitimation; but it also, concerningly, exists to advance the interests

of multinationals, corporations and for-profit businesses. There are clear *investments* within this network in privileging certain research methodologies and the validation, legitimization of research 'knowledge', which is then distributed to schools, teachers and students. Further, it is highly questionable whether this organisation will improve the capacities of public schools to adequately resource their schools, cater for their students in differentiated ways or provide 'high quality' education for students.

Finally, drawing upon a metaphor for conceptualising a policy network (Knox et al., 2006), such as the dingo-proof fence, may be useful in conceptualising a policy network as put together, held together, assembled and strategically constructed. This translation into a relatively stable set of ideas, positioning evidence as impartial and singular, is one that is performed and embodied within a range of durable materials, such as websites, statutory authority, evidence rubrics, or RCTs, and government legislation. Governance via selective networks and the assemblage of stable structures, that endeavour to render education evidence into a 'neutral' or inanimate object, is concerning for matters of democracy, transparency and accountability.

## Acknowledgement

The development of this paper was gratefully supported by the Australian Research Council Discovery Early Career Researcher Award (DE210100513). The project is titled: 'Venture Philanthropy in Public Education: Governance, Policy and Practice'.

Human Ethics was granted by Deakin University, although this paper does not draw on interviews. Thank you to the three anonymous reviewers for their generous scholarly input into strengthening this paper. Thank you to my anonymous corporate lawyer associate who provided me advice on corporate structures for this publication, pro-bono.

## Appendix 1

The analysis as presented in this paper was undertaken in 2021 and therefore, the networks as presented in this paper reflect this time-period. The relations are all verifiable. All data sources included in the reference list.

### **Australian Securities and Investments Commission (ASIC) reports:**

Australian Education Research Organisation Limited- Purchased and downloaded 16/10/2021: (1) Constitution of Company; (2) Current and Historical Company Extract; (3) Current Company Extract; (4) Relational Company Extract.

Social Ventures Australia (SVA)- Purchased and downloaded on 14/10/2021: (1) Current and Historical Company extract; (2) Current Company Extract; (3) Relational Company Extract; (4) Satisfied Charges Extract; (5) SVA Certificate of the Registration of a Company (Company Constitution).

ASIC purchased reports for Social Ventures Australia Subsidiaries:

SVA Nominees Pty Ltd: (1) Current and Historical Company Extract. Downloaded on 14/10/2021.

SVA Nominees No. 2 Pty Ltd: (1) Current and Historical Company Extract; (2) Relational Company Extract. Downloaded 26/10/2021.

Newpin: (1) Current and historical company extra; (2) Current company extract; (3) Relational company extract. Downloaded 16/10/2021.

Australian Philanthropic Services (APS): (1) Current and historical company extract; (2) Current Company Extract. Downloaded 14/10/2021.

Evidence for Learning: ASIC records not available. ASIC search carried out on 14/10/2021.

### **Correspondence with government departments:**

- 1) AERO financial records were requested via ASIC on 15 October 2021, under the *Freedom of Information Act 1982*. I was advised that the financial records for AERO are not obtainable under the following guideline: 'Section 24A(1) of the FOI Act states "an agency or minister may refuse a request for access to a document if... the agency or Minister is satisfied that the document does not exist' ([Australian Taxation Office, 2021](#)). This is likely due to the timing of the request. Companies are not required to submit audited financials within their first eighteen months. It is recommended that further access be sought in late 2022.
- 2) Public Governance, Performance and Accountability, Department of Finance, Canberra, November 2021: Author Correspondence.

**Emma Rowe** is an ARC DECRA Fellow and Senior Lecturer in Education at Deakin University. Emma is a recipient of an Australian Research Council Discovery Early Career Researcher Award (DECRA) 2021-2024, studying venture philanthropy in public education. She is a Fulbright Scholar and will undertake a residency at Indiana University, hosted by Professor Chris Lubienski in 2022. Her work is regularly featured in leading Australian media, including newspaper and television. She publishes in Q1 journals including *Journal of Education Policy*, the *Australian Educational Researcher* and *Discourse: Studies in the Cultural Politics of Education*. She currently serves as an Associate Editor for *Critical Studies in Education*.

## References

- ABC News. (2021). *New independent agency in charge of boosting Australia's education standards*. Retrieved from <https://www.dailymotion.com/video/x7zkeh>.
- ACNC. (2021). *Australian Charities and Not-for-profits Commission (ACNC)*. Social Ventures Australia Limited. Retrieved from <https://www.acnc.gov.au/charity/charities/a4972dd7-2daf-e811-a960-000d3ad24282/profile>.
- AERO. (2021a). *Australian Education Research Organisation: About AERO*. Retrieved from <https://edresearch.edu.au/about-aero>.
- AERO. (2021b). *Evidence Rubric*. Retrieved from <https://www.edresearch.edu.au/evidence/evidence-rubric>.
- AERO. (2021c). *Standards of Evidence*. Retrieved from <https://www.edresearch.edu.au/evidence/standards-evidence>.
- AERO. (2021d). *Strategic Plan 2021-2024*. Retrieved from <https://www.edresearch.edu.au/sites/default/files/2021-09/strategic-plan.pdf>.
- AERO. (2022). *Australian Education Research Organisation: Meet our Board*. Retrieved from <https://www.edresearch.edu.au/about-aero/meet-our-board>.
- Anderson, G., De La Cruz, P., & López, A. (2017). New Governance and New Knowledge Brokers: Think Tanks and Universities as Boundary Organizations. *Peabody Journal of Education*, 92(1), 4–15. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0161956X.2016.1264793>
- ASIC. (2021a). *Australian Education Research Organisation Limited. Report purchased on 14/10/21: Current and historical company information*. Retrieved from Australian Securities & Investments Commission. [https://connectonline.asic.gov.au/RegistrySearch/faces/landing/SearchRegisters.jspx?\\_adf.ctrl-state=jlk0tq7ua\\_4](https://connectonline.asic.gov.au/RegistrySearch/faces/landing/SearchRegisters.jspx?_adf.ctrl-state=jlk0tq7ua_4).
- ASIC. (2021b). *Australian Education Research Organisation Limited. Report purchased on 14/10/21: Details of registration of corporations(s), Constitution of Company (218)*. Retrieved from Australian Securities & Investments Commission. [https://connectonline.asic.gov.au/RegistrySearch/faces/landing/SearchRegisters.jspx?\\_adf.ctrl-state=jlk0tq7ua\\_4](https://connectonline.asic.gov.au/RegistrySearch/faces/landing/SearchRegisters.jspx?_adf.ctrl-state=jlk0tq7ua_4).
- ASIC. (2021c). *Australian Philanthropic Services Limited. Purchased report on 28/11/2021: Current and Historical Company Information*. Retrieved from Australian Securities & Investments Commission. [https://connectonline.asic.gov.au/RegistrySearch/faces/landing/panelSearch.jspx?searchTab=search&searchText=AUSTRALIAN+PHILANTHROPIC+SERVICES&searchType=OrgAndBusNm&\\_adf.ctrl-state=jlk0tq7ua\\_39](https://connectonline.asic.gov.au/RegistrySearch/faces/landing/panelSearch.jspx?searchTab=search&searchText=AUSTRALIAN+PHILANTHROPIC+SERVICES&searchType=OrgAndBusNm&_adf.ctrl-state=jlk0tq7ua_39).
- ASIC. (2021d). *Social Ventures Australia Limited. Report purchased on 14/10/2021: Current and Historical Company Information*. Retrieved from Australian Securities & Investments Commission. [https://connectonline.asic.gov.au/RegistrySearch/faces/landing/panelSearch.jspx?searchTab=search&searchText=social+ventures+australia&searchType=OrgAndBusNm&\\_adf.ctrl-state=jlk0tq7ua\\_22](https://connectonline.asic.gov.au/RegistrySearch/faces/landing/panelSearch.jspx?searchTab=search&searchText=social+ventures+australia&searchType=OrgAndBusNm&_adf.ctrl-state=jlk0tq7ua_22).
- Australian Business Register. (2022). *Australian Business Registry: Social Ventures Australia*. Retrieved from <https://www.abr.business.gov.au/ABN/View/94100487572>.
- Australian Government. (2001). *Commonwealth Consolidated Acts: Corporations Act 2001 [No. 50, 2001]*. Retrieved from <https://www.legislation.gov.au/Details/C2019C00216>.
- Australian Government. (2002). *Community-Business Partnership Develops New Tax Initiatives to Promote Philanthropy. Prime Minister Transcripts: Transcripts from the Prime Ministers of Australia [Transcript ID: 12131]*. Retrieved from <https://pmtranscripts.pmc.gov.au/release/transcript-12131>.
- Australian Government. (2011). *Australian Government Review of Funding for Schooling: Final Report December 2011. (The Gonski Review)*. Canberra City, ACT: Department of Education, Employment and Workplace Relations.
- Australian Government. (2013). *Public Governance, Performance and Accountability Act 2013*. Retrieved from <https://www.legislation.gov.au/Details/C2017C00269>.
- Australian Government. (2016). *Media Release, The Hon Scott Morrison: Appointment of Commissioner - Productivity Commission (18 November 2016)*. Retrieved from <https://ministers.treasury.gov.au/ministers/scott-morrison-2015/media-releases/appointment-commissioner-productivity-commission>.
- Australian Government. (2018). *Through Growth to Achievement: Report of the Review to Achieve Educational Excellence in Australian Schools*. Retrieved from Canberra, Australia <https://docs.education.gov.au/node/50516>.
- Australian Government. (2020a). *Ministers' Media Centre: Department of Education, Skills and Employment. Media Release, 12th June 2020 by the Hon. Dan Tehan MP. "\$50 million institute to drive educational outcomes"*. Retrieved from <https://ministers.dese.gov.au/tehan/50-million-institute-drive-educational-outcomes>.
- Australian Government. (2020b). *Public Governance, Performance and Accountability (Relevant Company) Amendment (2020 Measures No. 1) Rules 2020 (Dated 21 September 2020)*. Retrieved from <https://www.legislation.gov.au/Details/F2020L01234>.
- Australian Government.. (2021). *Australian Government, Department of the Prime Minister and Cabinet: Social Impact Investing Taskforce*. Retrieved from <https://www.pmc.gov.au/domestic-policy/social-impact-investing-taskforce>.
- Australian Government Productivity Commission. (2016a). *National Education Evidence Base. Productivity Commission Draft Report*. Retrieved from <http://www.pc.gov.au/inquiries/current/education-evidence/draft>.
- Australian Government Productivity Commission. (2016b). *National Education Evidence Base: Productivity Commission Draft Report. Overview and Recommendations. Released September 2016 Productivity Commission Draft Report*. Retrieved from <http://www.pc.gov.au/inquiries/current/education-evidence/draft>.
- Australian Government Productivity Commission. (2016c). *National Education Evidence Base: Productivity Commission Inquiry Report. No. 80, 9 December 2016*. Retrieved from <https://www.pc.gov.au/inquiries/completed/education-evidence/report/education-evidence.pdf>.
- Australian Taxation Office. (2021). *Decision Regarding your Freedom of Information Request. Request made under Freedom of Information Act 1982 (FOI Act)*. Retrieved from Correspondence with Author, dated 8th November 2021. .
- Avelar, M., & Ball, S. J. (2019). Mapping new philanthropy and the heterarchical state: The Mobilization for the National Learning Standards in Brazil. *International Journal of Educational Development*, 64, 65–73. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijedudev.2017.09.007>
- Ball, S. J. (2007). *Education plc: Understanding private sector participation in public sector education*. London: Routledge.
- Ball, S. J. (2009). Beyond Networks? A Brief Response to 'Which Networks Matter in Education Governance?'. *Political Studies*, 57, 688–691.
- Ball, S. J. (2012). *Global education inc.: new policy networks and the neo-liberal imaginary*. Abingdon, Oxon; New York: Routledge.
- Ball, S. J. (2016). Following policy: networks, network ethnography and education policy mobilities. *Journal of Education Policy*, 31(5), 1–18. <https://doi.org/10.1080/02680939.2015.1122232>
- Ball, S. J., & Exley, S. (2010). Making policy with 'good ideas': policy networks and the 'intellectuals' of New Labour. *Journal of Education Policy*, 25(2), 151–169. <https://doi.org/10.1080/02680930903486125>
- Ball, S. J., & Junemann, C. (2012). *Networks, New Governance and Education*. Bristol, UK and Chicago, USA: The Policy Press.
- Ball, S. J., Junemann, C., & Santori, D. (2017). *Edu.net: globalisation and education policy mobility*. Abingdon, Oxon; New York, NY: Routledge.
- Borgatti, S., & Halgin, D. (2011). Analyzing Affiliation Networks. *The Sage Handbook of Social Network Analysis*, 1. <https://doi.org/10.4135/9781446294413.n28>
- COAG. (2018). *National School Reform Agreement*. Retrieved from Australian Government Department of Education and Training: <https://docs.education.gov.au/node/51606>.
- Collins, K. (2018). *Kevan Collins interview with Evidence for Learning*. Retrieved from <https://educationendowmentfoundation.org.uk/news/kevan-collins-interview-with-evidence-for-learning/>.
- DeBray, E., Hanley, J., Scott, J., & Lubienski, C. (2019). Money and influence: philanthropies, intermediary organisations, and Atlanta's 2017 school board election. *Journal of Educational Administration and History*, 1–17. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00220620.2019.1689103>
- Deeble, M., & Vaughan, T. (2018). An evidence broker for Australian schools. Centre for Strategic Education. *Occasional Paper*, 155. April 2018. Retrieved from <https://evidenceforlearning.org.au/assets/Collateral/CSE-Occasional-Paper-An-evidence-broker-for-Australian-schools-.pdf>.
- Department for Education UK, Gove, M. (2010). *Press release by the Department for Education and The Rt Hon Michael Gove MP: New endowment fund to turn around weakest schools and raise standards for disadvantaged pupils*. Published 3 November 2010. Retrieved from <https://www.gov.uk/government/news/new-endowment-fund-to-turn-around-weakest-schools-and-raise-standards-for-disadvantaged-pupils>.
- Donovan, J. (2021). How AERO is going to accelerate the use of evidence in education practice. Retrieved from <https://thinkforwardeducators.org/events/jenny-donovan-aero-dec2021>.
- Edoald, T., & Nevill, C. (2021). Working Out What Works: The Case of the Education Endowment Foundation in England. *ECNU Review of Education*, 4(1), 46–64. <https://doi.org/10.1177/2096531120913039>
- Education Council. (2019). *Education Council Communiqué : Thursday 12 December 2019*. Retrieved from <https://www.dese.gov.au/download/11994/education-council-communiqué-12-december-2019/22763/education-council-communiqué-12-december-2019/docx>.

- EEF. (2018). Building a global evidence ecosystem for teaching. Retrieved from <https://educationendowmentfoundation.org.uk/about/international-work/building-a-global-evidence-ecosystem-for-teaching/>.
- EEF. (2021). *EEF's international partnerships*. Retrieved from <https://educationendowmentfoundation.org.uk/about/international-work/eeefs-international-partnerships/>.
- Fisher, A. G., Mills, C. H., Lyons, M., Cornwell, W. K., & Letnic, M. (2021). Remote sensing of trophic cascades: multi-temporal landsat imagery reveals vegetation change driven by the removal of an apex predator. *Landscape Ecology*, 36(5), 1341–1358. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10980-021-01206-w>
- Gonski, D. (2015). *I Gave a Gonski: Selected Speeches by David Gonski*. Sydney, Australia: Penguin Books.
- Gorur, R. (2016). Seeing like PISA: A cautionary tale about the performativity of international assessments. *European Educational Research Journal*, 15(5), 598–616. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1474904116658299>
- Government of South Australia. (2021a). *Dog Fence Act 1946*. Retrieved from <https://www.legislation.sa.gov.au/LZ/C/A/DOG%20FENCE%20ACT%201946.aspx>.
- Government of South Australia. (2021b). *The Dog Fence Board*. Retrieved from [https://www.pir.sa.gov.au/biosecurity/introduced-pest-feral-animals/find\\_a\\_pest\\_animal/wild\\_dogs\\_and\\_dingoes/dog\\_fence/the\\_dog\\_fence\\_board](https://www.pir.sa.gov.au/biosecurity/introduced-pest-feral-animals/find_a_pest_animal/wild_dogs_and_dingoes/dog_fence/the_dog_fence_board).
- Gulson, K. N., Lewis, S., Lingard, B., Lubienski, C., Takayama, K., & Webb, P. T. (2017). Policy mobilities and methodology: a proposition for inventive methods in education policy studies. *Critical Studies in Education*, 1–18. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17508487.2017.1288150>
- Hogan, A., Sellar, S., & Lingard, B. (2016). Corporate Social Responsibility and Neo-Social Accountability in Education: The Case of Pearson plc. In A. Verger, C. Lubienski, & G. Steiner-Khamisi (Eds.), *World Yearbook of Education 2016: The Global Education Industry* (pp. 107–125). London & New York: Routledge.
- Holloway, J., & Larsen Hedegaard, M. L. (2021). Democracy and teachers: the im/possibilities for pluralisation in evidence-based practice. *Journal of Education Policy*, 1–20. <https://doi.org/10.1080/02680939.2021.2014571>
- Investopedia. (2021). *Broker*. Retrieved from <https://www.investopedia.com/terms/b/broker.asp>.
- Karp, P. (2018). *Labor pledges \$280m research institute to 'take politics out of the classroom'*. Retrieved from <https://www.theguardian.com/australia-news/2018/feb/16/labor-pledges-280m-research-institute-to-take-politics-out-of-the-classroom>.
- Knox, H., Savage, M., & Harvey, P. (2006). Social networks and the study of relations: networks as method, metaphor and form. *Economy and Society*, 35, 113–140, 1 (February 2006).
- Latour, B. (2002). Symposium: On Interobjectivity. The Lessons of Simian Societies. *Mind, Culture, and Activity*, 3(4), 228–245. Retrieved from <http://www.bruno-latour.fr/sites/default/files/63-INTEROBJECTS-GB.pdf>.
- Law, J. (1992). Notes on the theory of the actor-network: Ordering, strategy, and heterogeneity. *Systems Practice*, 5(4), 379–393. <https://doi.org/10.1007/BF01059830>
- Law, J. (1999). After ANT: complexity, naming and topology. *The Sociological Review*, 47(1), 1–14.
- Law, J., & Singleton, V. (2005). Object lessons. *Organization*, 12(3), 331–355. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1350508405051270>
- Lewis, S., & Hogan, A. (2019). Reform first and ask questions later? The implications of (fast) schooling policy and 'silver bullet' solutions. *Critical Studies in Education*, 60(1), 1–18. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17508487.2016.1219961>
- Lubienski, C., Scott, J., & DeBray, E. (2011). The rise of intermediary organizations in knowledge production, advocacy, and educational policy. *Teachers College Record*. Retrieved from <https://www.tcrecord.org/PrintContent.asp?ContentID=16487>.
- Morrison, S. (2016). Productivity Commission inquiry into the national school and early childhood education evidence base. Joint media release by the Hon. Scott Morrison MP, Treasurer of the Commonwealth of Australia and Senator the Hon. Simon Birmingham Minister for Education and Training. Retrieved from <https://ministers.dese.gov.au/smmorrison/productivity-commission-inquiry-national-school-and-early-childhood-education-evidence>.
- Peck, J., & Theodore, N. (2015). *Fast policy: experimental statecraft at the thresholds of neoliberalism*. Minneapolis & London: University of Minnesota Press.
- Philanthropy Australia (2021). Conference: The Future of Philanthropy in Australia. 13th October 2021.
- Rhodes, R. A. W. (1996). The New Governance: Governing without Government. *Political Studies*, 44(4), 652–667. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9248.1996.tb01747.x>
- Rowe, E. (2021). Venture philanthropy in public schools in Australia: tracing policy mobility and policy networks. *Journal of Education Policy*, 1–22. <https://doi.org/10.1080/02680939.2021.1973569>
- Rowe, E. (2022a). The Gonski Review and the rise of external actors in Australian education. In C. Lubienski, C. Maxwell, & M. Yemini (Eds.), *Rising Powers in Education: Global Trends and Local Implications*. New York: Routledge. (In press).
- Rowe, E. (2022b). Philanthrocapitalism and the state: mapping the rise of venture philanthropy in public education in Australia. *ECNU Review of Education, Special Issue: Policy Networks in Education (Edited by Santori, Diego)*. (In press).
- Schools Plus. (2019). Education and philanthropy heavyweights appointed to Schools Plus members committee. Retrieved from <https://www.schoolsplus.org.au/news-details/education-and-philanthropy-heavyweights-appointed-to-schools-plus-members-committee/>.
- Scott, J., & Jabbar, H. (2013). Money and measures: Foundations as knowledge brokers. In D. Anagnostopoulos, S. Rutledge, & R. Jacobsen (Eds.), *The infrastructure of accountability: Mapping data use and its consequences across the American education system* (pp. 75–92). Cambridge, UK: Harvard Education Press.
- Scott, J., & Jabbar, H. (2014). The Hub and the Spokes: Foundations, Intermediary Organizations, Incentivist Reforms, and the Politics of Research Evidence. *Educational Policy*, 28(2), 233–257. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0895904813515327>
- Solomon, S. (2018). *Mending Fences in the War Between Dingoes and Sheep*. Retrieved from <https://www.nytimes.com/2018/01/07/world/australia/dingo-fence-outback-south-australia.html>.
- SVA. (2013). *Social Ventures Australia Annual Financial Report (For the year ended 30 June 2013)*. Retrieved from <https://www.acnc.gov.au/charity/388fc70f00cf690c19037770b1de3338#financials-documents>.
- SVA. (2014). *Social Ventures Australia Annual Financial Report (For the year ended 30 June 2014)*. Retrieved from <https://www.acnc.gov.au/charity/388fc70f00cf690c19037770b1de3338#financials-documents>.
- SVA. (2015). *Social Ventures Australia Annual Financial Report (For the year ended 30 June 2015)*. Retrieved from <https://www.acnc.gov.au/charity/388fc70f00cf690c19037770b1de3338#financials-documents>.
- SVA. (2016). *Social Ventures Australia Submission to the Productivity Commission Inquiry into the National Education Evidence Base (May 2016)*. Retrieved from [https://www.pc.gov.au/\\_data/assets/pdf\\_file/0004/199714/sub059-education-evidence.pdf](https://www.pc.gov.au/_data/assets/pdf_file/0004/199714/sub059-education-evidence.pdf).
- SVA. (2017a). *Public submission made to the Review to Achieve Educational Excellence in Australian Schools*. Retrieved from <https://www.dese.gov.au/system/files/documents/document-file/2020-12/social-ventures-australia.pdf>.
- SVA. (2017b). *Social Ventures Australia Annual Financial Report (For the year ended 30 June 2017)*. Retrieved from <https://www.acnc.gov.au/charity/charities/a4972dd7-2daf-e811-a960-000d3ad24282/documents/>.
- SVA. (2018). *Social Ventures Australia Annual Financial Report (For the year ended 30 June 2018)*. Retrieved from <https://www.acnc.gov.au/charity/388fc70f00cf690c19037770b1de3338#financials-documents>.
- SVA. (2019). *Social Ventures Australia Annual Financial Report (For the year ended 30 June 2019)*. Retrieved from <https://www.acnc.gov.au/charity/388fc70f00cf690c19037770b1de3338#financials-documents>.
- SVA. (2020). *Social Ventures Australia Annual Financial Report (For the year ended 30 June 2020)*. Retrieved from <https://www.acnc.gov.au/charity/charities/a4972dd7-2daf-e811-a960-000d3ad24282/documents/>.
- SVA (2021). 2021-22 Pre-budget Submission to the Australian Government. Retrieved from Social Ventures Australia: <https://www.socialventures.com.au/assets/SVA-2021-22-Pre-budget-Submission-to-the-Australian-Government.pdf>.
- Traill, M. (2016). *Jumping Ship: from the world of corporate Australia to the heart of social investment*. London, UK and Richmond, Australia: Hardie Grant Books.
- Urban, R. (2021). Radical school of thought: use evidence-based teaching methods. Retrieved from <https://www.theaustralian.com.au/nation/radical-school-of-thought-use-evidencebased-teaching-methods/news-story/1d2f290413a950641c28f6f35dbc81ae>.